

Poetry Reading





About the Course

Students continue to develop their relationship with words through ongoing exposure to a variety of poetic forms, poet biographies, and 19th century poems.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Poetry: Grade 8



Placement & Combining Tips

Students in Grades 5-8 can easily be combined for these lessons as all grades use nearly the same texts this year, although Grades 7-8 read additional selections and have corresponding composition assignments. Poetry lessons are also an integral part of the whole Literature program, so look at both literature and poetry selections together when placing students. Students in Grades 9+ new to poetry should begin here.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
8	Poetry Reading: Grade 8 4 times/week 5 min	Jump Back, Paul: The Life and Poems of Paul Laurence Dunbar The Poet: Pauline Johnson Over the River and Through the Wood: An Anthology of Nineteenth-Century American Children's Poetry The Crescent Moon

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Poetry: Grade 8				
Poetry Reading: Grade 8	Poetry Reading: Grade 8	Poetry Reading: Grade 8	Poetry Reading: Grade 8	Poetry Study: Grade 8



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Poetry Reading: Grade 8



Jump Back, Paul: The Life and Poems of Paul Laurence Dunbar



The Poet: Pauline Johnson



Over the River and Through the Wood: An Anthology of Nineteenth-Century American Children's Poetry



The Crescent Moon



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

∞ [Over the River Public Domain Poetry List](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



Poetry Reading: Grade 8

How To Teach



Introduce

Tell something about the poet or the kind of poem or fable to prepare students. Remember that poems are like paintings—they not only convey ideas, they create an experience with the sound of words, the way the words are arranged, and the emotions, thoughts, and images they evoke.



Read

Read the poem aloud in order to hear the sounds and meter. Have students read it aloud as well as it is helpful to hear poetry read by different voices. Try to read paying attention to the punctuation as well as the line breaks to get the sense of the poem.



Discuss

Allow students to share any thoughts or connections. What are your impressions of the poem? Talk about anything that stood out to you: the images, ideas, words, phrases, sounds, or even physical look of the poem. What kinds of things is the poem about?



Reread

Read (or have the student read) the poem again.



Connect

Students may choose to add poems to their Commonplace Book or mark them to copy later.

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

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Term 1

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 1

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ NOTE

You will usually spend one week reading the poems from ~5 pages (depending on the size of the illustrations and length of poems). You can pick 1-3 to read each day and reread them as much as you like. Poetry is made to be read many times. Lessons give some ideas for discussing a particular poem, but those are only suggestions. You'll also focus particularly on getting to know the poet Rabindranath Tagore in Term 1, Pauline Johnson in Term 2, and Paul Laurence Dunbar in Term 3. Feel free to use the index of the book to look up other poems by poets you particularly like.

→ INTRO

Almost all the poems we'll read this year were written from 1800-1900AD (the time period you'll learn about in many of your other lessons as well). So, as you read, imagine children like you listening to these same poems about 200 years ago! Let's start by reading a poem that reminds us to enjoy (and not overthink) the poems we'll read this year.

→ READ

∞ Link: Introduction To Poetry

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.31-36 Chapter: Growing Things

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week. (Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Optional: Read the Introduction and share information with students throughout the year.

Note: The "Holidays" chapter of Over the River and Through the Woods is not scheduled until term 3. Feel free to also read from that chapter during Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Years, etc.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 2

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Our poem today is by Paul Lawrence Dunbar. He was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other writers after him. He also became friends with Orville Wright and his brother Wilbur (who you may remember as the inventors of the airplane)! The Wright brothers owned a printing press and published Dunbar's first writings. You'll read an interesting biography about Paul Laurence Dunbar in Term 2 that includes several more of his poems.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.36 "The Seedling" by Paul Lawrence Dunbar.

- Do you notice how the seedling starts talking in the poem? Have you ever heard a seedling talk? Of course not! Poets sometimes imagine that things like plants or animals can talk to help us think about them in new ways. The fancy word for this is "personification." Do you notice any other examples of the seed doing things only people normally do?
- Keep your eyes open for other poems this week that use personification. What human traits do they give the trees or seeds? Look for examples in "Tree Feelings" by Charlotte Perkins Gilman on p.31.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 3

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.31 "Tree Feelings" by Charlotte Perkins Gilman

- How does the poet use personification in this poem? What human traits does the poet give the trees or seeds?

★ TEACHER NOTE

∞ **Article Link:** Tips for reading poetry out loud.

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

p.31-36 Chapter: Growing Things

Use any additional time to pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 4

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ INTRO

Rabindranath Tagore was born in 1861 in Calcutta, India, and grew up in a family that loved art, music, and ideas. He was a poet, short-story writer, composer, playwright, and painter who spent his life creating in many different ways. In 1913, he became the first non-European writer to be awarded the Nobel Prize for Literature. He also composed the national anthems for both India and Bangladesh, making his words a lasting part of two nations. Once a week this term, we'll explore poems by Rabindranath Tagore exploring themes like mothers, children, and nature.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.8 "On the Seashore"

- What are the children doing at the seashore?
- What might the "seashore of endless worlds" symbolize?

p.6-10 Pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 5

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Our poet today is Ina Coolbrith. She was born Josephine Smith. Her uncle Joseph Smith was the founder of the Mormon church, and her father (who died when she was just a few months old) was a church leader, though she concealed this most of her life. Her ties to the church were severed in childhood when her mother remarried a non-Mormon, and they moved to California to follow the gold rush. She published her first poems as a teenager and worked for over two decades as a librarian, encouraging the writing careers of others. She became California's first poet laureate in 1915.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.50 "In Blossom Time" by Ina Coolbrith

- "In Blossom Time" is written in a quatrain, meaning each verse contains exactly four lines. Sometimes a whole poem is written in a quatrain, as in this poem, and sometimes just part of the poem uses this structure. Quatrains usually have a specific rhyme structure. In this poem, the structure is ABCB, meaning that the words ending the second and fourth lines rhyme (B), but the first (A) and third lines (C) do not. Quatrains can have other rhyme structures, such as AABB or ABBA.

Extra Helping:

∞ Article Link: Ina Coolbrith bio

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 6

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Last lesson, we learned that a quatrain is when each verse in a poem has exactly four lines. We'll read two more poems that use this format today, but have different rhyme structures.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.44 "Prairie Fires" by Eudora May Stone.

- What is the rhyme scheme of "Prairie Fires"?

★ TEACHER NOTE

"Prairie Fires" has an ABAB rhyme scheme.

"The Mushroom's Soliloquy" has an AABB rhyme scheme.

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

p.46 "The Mushroom's Soliloquy" by Hannah Flagg Gould

- What is the rhyme scheme of "The Mushroom's Soliloquy"? Note that a soliloquy is when a character speaks their private thoughts or feelings out loud without anyone else around to hear them. What are some of the mushroom's thoughts?

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 7

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.45 "The Johnny Cake" Author Unknown

- "The Johnny Cake" has three lines per stanza, which is called a tercet. The pace of a tercet is often slower than a couplet or quatrain. What is the rhyme scheme?

p.44 Read "To Make A Prairie" by Emily Dickinson.

- Notice how "To Make A Prairie" is both very brief and uses an unconventional AAABB rhyme structure. Why might Dickinson have chosen this for her subject? Note that reverie means to daydream or be lost in imagination.

★ TEACHER NOTE

"The Johnny Cake" rhyme scheme is ABB.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 8

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.12-13 "Sleep-Stealer"

- Do you think someone really stole the baby's sleep?
- What phrase is repeated throughout the poem? Why do you think this is?
- How does the poem blur the line between the real world and the imaginative world?

p.11-15 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages. (Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 9

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

This poem was written during the Civil War by Walt Whitman. In fact, Whitman volunteered as a nurse caring for wounded soldiers, and the experience inspired some of his most powerful poems. We'll learn more about Walt Whitman later in the year.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.58 "Give Me The Splendid Sun" by Walt Whitman.

- What examples of alliteration (repeated sounds) and/or repetition (repeated words) can you find in this poem?

The poem in our book leaves out some lines. The verse ends like this:

These demanding to have them, (tired with ceaseless excitement,
and rack'd by the war-strife,)

These to procure incessantly asking, rising in cries from my heart,
While yet incessantly asking still I adhere to my city,
Day upon day and year upon year O city, walking your streets,
Where you hold me enchain'd a certain time refusing to give me
up,
Yet giving to make me glutt'd, enrich'd of soul, you give me

★ TEACHER NOTE

The full poem is split into two distinct parts — the first longing for nature and solitude, the second embracing the city. However, the second part does include content that may not be suitable for your students, so it is not included in the book or the lesson.

• COMPOSITION

Knowing of Walt Whitman's experience as a Civil War nurse, how does the line about being "rack'd by the war-strife" impact Whitman's longing for peaceful nature?

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forever faces;
(O I see what I sought to escape, confronting, reversing my cries,
I see my own soul trampling down what it ask'd for.)

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 10

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.59 "A Day" Emily Dickinson

We previously read Emily Dickinson's "To Make A Prairie" (p. 44), which used an unconventional rhyme structure. "A Day" includes a more traditional quatrain (four-line verse) and rhyme structure. Can you identify what that rhyme structure is?

★ TEACHER NOTE

"A Day" rhyme scheme is ABCB.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 11

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57-62 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 12

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p. 19 "Playthings"

- How does the poem compare child's play to adult work, and which seems more satisfying?
- What "art" has the adult forgotten?
- What does the poem mean when it says adults spend their lives seeking "costly playthings"? Does this create success and happiness?

p.16-19 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 13

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

John Greenleaf Whittier is known as a passionate abolitionist opposing slavery long before the Civil War, a prolific writer, and a friend to several other famous writers. During his lifetime, he became one of America's most popular poets. He also ran for Congress twice and remained involved in politics throughout his life. He spent his later years writing about religion, nature, and country life. He moved in a remarkable circle of friends that included abolitionist Frederick Douglass, poets Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, and novelist Mark Twain.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.73 "The Barefoot Boy" by John Greenleaf Whittier.

- This poem uses a metaphor, which is a comparison of two things that are generally unlike. In this case, a boy is compared with a prince. Common metaphors include phrases like "time is money". Metaphors are

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: John Greenleaf Whittier bio

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sometimes confused with similes, which also compare two things but contain the words "like" or "as," such as "life is like a roller coaster". What are some more examples of a metaphor and/or a simile?

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 14

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.70-76 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

(Optional) Use today and tomorrow to write a poem about the month or season it is currently.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 15

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.70-76 Chapter: Landscapes and Seasons
Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

(Optional) Write a poem about the month or season it is currently.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 16

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.23-24 "Fairyland"
• Why do you think the child whispers the secret to the mother instead of telling everyone?
• In what ways can imagination transform ordinary places into something wondrous and special?

→ VIEW

∞ Picture Link: Tulsi plant

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.20-24 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 17

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

You may already recognize Louisa May Alcott as the author of Little Women, but she is also recognized as a poet. Growing up in Concord, Massachusetts, her family was neighbors and friends with writers and poets Ralph Waldo Emerson, Henry David Thoreau, and Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, all of whom influenced her love of writing from an early age. She wrote novels, short stories, and poetry that often drew on her own life and the social causes she cared about, including abolition and women's rights. Her poetry also often reflected the Transcendentalist love of nature, finding meaning and beauty in the natural world.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.83 "Morning Song of the Bees" by Louisa May Alcott
• Look for rhymes and mark which words rhyme. Can you find a pattern?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Louisa May Alcott bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

This poem uses an ABCB rhyme scheme in the first 8 lines, but then changes to an AABCCB scheme in the refrain (the last 6 lines). This creates a "bouncing" effect much like bees bouncing from flower to flower. The poem almost sounds like a song or hymn when read aloud.

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WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 18

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.79 "The Lady-Bug And the Ant" by Lydia Sigourney

- The Ant notices the Lady-Bug's mockery but simply keeps walking "at the same industrious pace." What does this tell us about the Ant's character? Why might the poet have chosen not to have the Ant respond with words?
- What is the lesson the Lady-Bug learns? The poem ends without telling us what happens to the Lady-Bug when winter arrives. Why do you think the poet left this part out?
- This poem was written for children in 1836. Do you think its message still applies today? Can you think of modern examples that reflect the same ideas?

★ TEACHER NOTE

To keep to the lesson time, you may want to choose just one discussion question you think students will enjoy most and save the others for the next lesson (if students are really interested).

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 19

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.82-85 Chapter: Creepie Crawlies

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 20

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.28-29 "Paper Boats"

- What is inside the boat during the poem?
- What do you think the child imagines will happen to the paper boats on their journey?
- Why do you think the child hopes that "someone in some strange land" will find the boats?

→ VIEW

∞ Picture Link: Shiuli flower (The English name is night-blooming jasmine.)

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.25-29 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 21

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Helen Hunt Jackson experienced many hardships in her life. She turned to writing to help her through her grief and went on to publish poetry, children's books, and travel writing. She also happened to grow up as a close friend of poet Emily Dickinson! Later in life, Jackson became a fierce champion for Native American rights, writing a book called *A Century of Dishonor* (1881) after hearing a moving speech by Chief Standing Bear, and then a novel called *Ramona* (1884) that told the story of California's displaced Mission Indians.

→ READ & DISCUSS

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Helen Hunt Jackson bio

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p.103 "The Shining Little House" by Helen Hunt Jackson.

- How many lines are in each stanza (verse) of the poem? Can you identify the rhyme structure?
- What rhymes do you see? Is there a pattern?
- What do you think the lesson of this poem is? Do you agree?

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 22

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ NOTE

The next lesson includes "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe. Preview to see if the poem is too intense for your students.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.101 "Robert of Lincoln" by William Cullen Bryant

- Bryant uses a classic poetic device called onomatopoeia at the end of each stanza. Onomatopoeia is when a word phonetically imitates the sound it describes, such as buzz, hiss, bang, or sizzle. Can you think of some other onomatopoeic words?

Use any additional time to explore more poems from p. 101-104 Chapter: Feathered Friends

★ TEACHER NOTE

∞ **Audio & Video Link:** How to pronounce onomatopoeia.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 23

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ NOTE

This lesson includes "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe. Preview to see if the poem is too intense for your students.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.105-107 "The Raven" by Edgar Allan Poe

- "The Raven" has a very strong, almost musical beat that you can feel when you read it aloud. How does that steady, pounding rhythm affect the mood of the poem?
- Poe uses a lot of rhyme and repetition, especially at the end of each stanza. How does hearing the same word over and over change the way it feels by the end of the poem, compared to the first time it appears?
- Can you find examples of onomatopoeia in "The Raven"?

OR

p.101-104 Chapter: Feathered Friends

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

★ TEACHER NOTE

- One example of onomatopoeia is "the silken sad uncertain rustling".
- To keep to the lesson time, you may want to choose just one discussion question you think students will enjoy most and save the others for the next lesson (if students are really interested).

• COMPOSITION

Imagine the story continues after the poem ends. The raven is still sitting on the bust above the door when the speaker wakes up the next morning. Write a scene (in either prose or poetry) describing what happens next.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 24

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.33-34 "The Merchant"

- What gifts would you bring home if you traveled to magical lands like the child in the poem?
- What do the different gifts chosen for the mother, father, and brother reveal about how the child sees each person?

p.30-34 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

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WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 25

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Emily Dickinson spent almost her whole life in Amherst, Massachusetts, rarely leaving her family home. She was a serious gardener who grew all kinds of flowers and plants, and you can see her love of nature all over her poems, which are full of flowers, bees, and changing seasons that she observed right in her own backyard. Even though she only published a small handful of poems while she was alive, she secretly wrote nearly 1,800 of them, and most weren't discovered until after she died in 1886. Today, she's considered one of the greatest American poets. Imagine her going back and forth between her garden and her writing desk, getting inspired by everything she saw growing around her.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.125 "In the Garden" by Emily Dickinson

- The poem is titled "In the Garden," yet the garden itself is never really described. Why might Dickinson have chosen that title?
- In the third stanza, Dickinson uses an em dash -- some consider this her signature style! The dashes in her poems create pauses and make the reader slow down. These em dashes are often left out of her poems when they are reprinted. Unfortunately, they were left out of many of her poems in this book. Note that many people today consider the use of em dashes a sign that something was written by AI (such as ChatGPT)!

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Emily Dickinson bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

You can find the original versions of Dickinson's poems online to see where the em dashes were placed.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 26

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.123 "Humming-Bird Song" by Frank Dempster Sherman

- Notice how the short, fast lines sound similar to how a hummingbird quickly darts around when read aloud!

As time allows, explore p.122-126 Chapter: Feathered Friends (Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 27

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.122-126 Chapter: Feathered Friends

Pick and choose poems from these pages.

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 28

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.36 "Vocation"

- Why does the child think the hawker, gardener, and watchman have exciting lives?
- How does the poem contrast school life with the child's longing for independence?
- What does the poem suggest about our tendency to imagine that other lives are freer or happier than our own?

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p.35-39 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 29

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

American poet Laura E. Richards had pretty impressive parents! Her mother was Julia Ward Howe, who wrote "Battle Hymn of the Republic," and her father ran the Perkins Institution for the Blind. She followed in her family's accomplished footsteps by writing nearly a hundred books, becoming a pioneer of nonsense poetry for kids, and one of her stories was even turned into a movie. She and her sister won the Pulitzer Prize for Biography for a book they wrote about their famous mother, making them the first women ever to win that award.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.134 "The Sad Story of the Dandy Cat" by Laura Richards

- A dandy is a man who cares too much about appearances and fashion.
- Using an animal to comment on human behavior is called allegory. Can you think of other stories where an animal is used to comment on human behavior? What makes using an animal an effective way to deliver that kind of message to a reader?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Laura E. Richards bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

Other examples of allegory would be any of Aesop's Fables and the book Charlotte's Web.

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 30

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

This poem originated from an old British nursery rhyme, though it's usually attributed to American Eliza Lee Cabot Follen. The earliest known published version was in 1817, while Follen's version was published later in 1841.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.132 "The Three Little Kittens" by Eliza Lee Cabot Follen

- Like "The Sad Story of the Dandy Cat", this poem also uses allegory to deliver a moral or lesson. What is the lesson (or lessons) being taught here?

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 31

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.129-132 Chapter: Domestic Animals

(Optional) Write a poem about a pet you have (or would like to have).

Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 32

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.40 "Authorship"

- Did you catch the line about the child making a paper boat? Do you think this is the same child who made paper boats in a previous poem?
- What kinds of stories does the child wish the father would write?
- How does the poem show the difference between the way children and

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

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adults value work, play, and creativity?

p.40-45 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 33

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Ella Wheeler Wilcox grew up on a farm in Wisconsin, started writing poetry around age eight, and was widely published in magazines by the time she was a teen! She became one of the most widely read American poets of her era. She wrote nearly 40 books of poetry and prose, including the famous lines "Laugh, and the world laughs with you; weep, and you weep alone", which she wrote after comforting a grieving widow on a train. She was also a passionate advocate for animal rights, and this topic came up in several of her poems, like "The Hen's Complaint".

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.145-146 "The Hen's Complaint" by Ella Wheeler Wilcox.

- "The Hen's Complaint" uses rhyming couplets. This is when two lines rhyme, usually have the same number of syllables, and usually form a complete sentence or thought. It creates a very "sing-song" cadence that you'll find used everywhere from Dr. Seuss to Shakespeare! We'll learn more about these in a later lesson.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 34

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.143 "The Motherless Turkeys" by Marian Douglass

- How would you describe the character of the duck? Goose? Dorking? Hen with one chicken?
- Do you remember what an allegory is? This poem also uses allegory to deliver a moral or a lesson. What is the lesson (or lessons) being taught here?

• TERMINOLOGY

A dorking is an English breed of chicken.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 35

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.141-142 "Mary's Lamb" Parodies.

(You'll find the original poem at the top of the page and the parodies after.)

(Optional) Write your own parody of a common poem or rhyme.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 36

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.49 "The Banyan Tree" The Banyan tree is the national tree of India.

- Why do you think the child wants to be the wind, a bird, or a duck?
- How does the poem show movement through the images it describes?
- What might the child learn from quietly watching nature every day?

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Parable of the Banyan Tree

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

p.46-49 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 37

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Ralph Waldo Emerson was a Boston-born writer, poet, and philosopher who became one of the most influential thinkers in American history. He was unusually curious about Eastern cultures for his time, and he wove ideas from Hindu, Persian, and Chinese texts into his writing. He had some of the cultural blind spots common to people of his era, but he genuinely broadened the horizons of American readers by introducing them to ideas and traditions from around the world.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.155 "Fable" by Ralph Waldo Emerson

- An allegory typically has two levels of understanding: the literal (the quarrel between the mountain and the squirrel) and the symbolic (what deeper story or moral is being told). What do you think might be the deeper story or moral in this poem?

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 38

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

This poem has an interesting premise. Read the explanation before the poem (in italics) and then read the poem.

p.154 "Billy Rabbit to Mary" by Eliza Lee Cabot Follen (page 154)

(Optional) Write your own "response poem" from an animal to a human. Perhaps it's from a cat who had to be given a bath, or a dog who did something his owners weren't happy about.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 39

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Chapter: Wild Animals

p.153-157 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

As time allows, use the author index in the back to explore more poems by any of the poets we have been introduced to so far.

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 40

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.54 "The Last Bargain".

- Why do you think the child chooses the child instead of the king, the old man, or the fair maiden?
- What do you think the speaker discovers about freedom by the end of the poem?

p.50-54 If time allows, pick and choose poems from these pages.
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 41

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.161-163 "The War of the Rats and Mice (Almost A Fairy Tale)" by George W. Ranck

- Why do you think the poet named this "almost a fairy tale"?
- Epic ancient poems like The Iliad tell stories of great warriors and heroes fighting for honor and glory. Ranck uses that same structure but fills it with rats and mice instead of legendary heroes. What makes this contrast humorous? What might Ranck be suggesting about the nature of war and the reasons creatures fight?

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 42

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: What Are Rhyming Couplets?

(Optional) Using "The War of the Rats and Mice (Almost A Fairy Tale)" on pages 161-163, try the exercise in the video where one student (or group of students or teacher) reads the end word of a line and another student (or group of students) reads the end word of the next line.

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 43

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Chapter: Wild Animals

p.161-165 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week. Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.

- Several poems this term were by "anonymous" or "author unknown". Why might some poets have chosen to publish poems anonymously in the 1800's?

Use any extra time to catch up on any lessons or reread favorite poems from this term.

• COMPOSITION

Several poems this term were by "anonymous" or "author unknown". Given what you know about this time period in history, why might some poets have chosen to publish poems anonymously in the 1800's?

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 44

Materials: Crescent Moon

→ READ & DISCUSS

Revisit favorite poems from Crescent Moon or use this time to catch up on previous lessons.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 45

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 46

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

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WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 47

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 48

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

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Term 2

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 49

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Eugene Field was an American poet, journalist, and humorist who built a remarkable career working his way through newspapers across the Midwest, eventually becoming one of the most widely read columnists in the United States. Known as "The Children's Poet," he wrote more than a dozen volumes of poetry and created some of the most beloved children's poems in American literature. His writing was deeply personal, drawing on memories of his New England childhood, his marriage, and the joys of raising a large family. He claimed to be terrible with money and had all his earnings sent directly to his wife to manage.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.181 "The Duel"

- This poem has an unreliable narrator. This means that the person telling the story can't be trusted. In this case, the poet tells you at the end of each stanza that he got his information from a Chinese plate and an old Dutch clock! He also keeps reminding you not to doubt him (which has the opposite effect), and the improbable ending is delivered with total confidence and zero evidence! It's almost as if the poet is winking at us and letting us in on the joke.

If time allows, read the poem a second time, looking for these signs (and more) of an unreliable narrator.

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 50

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

As you read, look for some of the poetic devices we discussed last term, like repetition, onomatopoeia, rhyme structure, etc.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.182 "The Song of the Roller Skates" by A.C.

- Have you been to a roller skating rink? Why do you think the poem is divided into two parts (the start and the turn)?
- Read the poem again out loud and see if you feel like you are skating as you read.

★ TEACHER NOTE

Reminder: onomatopoeia is when a word sounds like what it means. Swoop, whiz, and whirl would be examples.

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 51

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Emily Pauline Johnson was born to a Mohawk chief and an English mother, growing up on the Six Nations Reserve in Ontario. She was educated at home, where she was immersed in both English literary traditions and Mohawk oral storytelling and developed a love for poetry. At a time when Indigenous peoples regularly faced discrimination, she was raised to value her dual heritage. After her father's death, she turned to writing and performing to help support her family, traveling across Canada for 17 years. The first half of each of her shows was performed in Indigenous dress and the second half in an English gown, embodying the two cultures that made her who she was. She published her work under both "E. Pauline Johnson" and her Mohawk name, Tekahionwake.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57 "The Song My Paddle Sings" by E. Pauline Johnson (Tekahionwake; Mohawk)

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

- What do you remember about personification? Can you find examples of personification in this poem?
- Notice how the poem also includes whole words that are repeated like "blow, blow" and "sleep, sleep." These repetitions help us feel the rhythm of a paddle dipping into the water time and time again.

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 52

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ INTRO

We met Pauline Johnson and learned a little about her in the last lesson. Today, we'll start reading a few pages from a biography about her. We will continue to read her poems and her biography throughout the term.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.1-4

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Pauline Johnson bio (as time allows)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Use this biography if you are not using the book "The Poet: Pauline Johnson". You will need to substitute some of the lessons' reading from the book with additional poems. Besides the poems in Over the River and Through the Woods, you can find more of Johnson's poems here. (Scroll down to see linked poems. Teachers should preview poems first.)

∞ Article Link: Alternative bio

∞ Link: Additional Pauline Johnson poems

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 53

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow was born in Portland, Maine in 1807 and published his first poem at just 13 years old. After college, he became a professor at Harvard and could speak eight languages, which helped make his poetry rich with ideas and stories from around the world. He became the most popular American poet of his time, writing famous works like "Paul Revere's Ride" and "The Song of Hiawatha". Some of his phrases (like "ships that pass in the night") became so well known that people still use them today without even knowing Longfellow wrote them. He faced heartbreak in his life, including losing two wives, but he kept writing through it all and remained one of the most loved poets in the world until he died in 1882.

→ READ & DISCUSS

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow dedicated the poem "The Castle-Builder" in 1848 to his son Erny Longfellow. There were six children in the family (five who lived to adulthood). Charley and Erny were the Longfellow's two oldest children. In a journal entry from 1848, Fanny Longfellow (Henry's wife) wrote "Erny promises to be the poet, Charley the man of action." Erny grew up to be a painter. Charley ran away to be a soldier in the Civil War and later became a world traveler.

p.185 "The Castle-Builder" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- In what ways does the poem show a boy growing into a man?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Henry Wadsworth Longfellow bio

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 54

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.185-189 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

Chapter: Toys and Play

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

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As time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by poets we have been introduced to this year.

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 55

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Words which repeat the same sounds (called alliteration) to help create rhythm in poetry and writing (and marketing!). Alliteration is the repetition of consonant sounds, particularly at the beginnings of words. While it is common in poetry, you can find alliteration everywhere. Examples include brand names like Coca-Cola and Dunkin' Donuts, and popular phrases like "tried and true" or "good as gold". Listen for the alliteration in today's poem by Pauline Johnson.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.57 "The Song My Paddle Sings" by E. Pauline Johnson (Tekahionwake; Mohawk)

- Read this poem again today and listen for the alliteration.
- What examples of alliteration did you find in this poem? Can you think of other brands or phrases that use alliteration? Once you start looking, you'll likely see it everywhere! Finally, notice how the repetition in this poem of words like "blow, blow" and "sleep, sleep" mimics the paddling of a canoe.

∞ Video Link: "Good as Gold" and Other Alliterations. The video matches the text, so you can either watch or read. (as time allows)

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 56

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p. 5-7

- The three men in the audience were all considered Canada's "Confederation Poets". These poets wrote in the same time period about similar themes include Canada's natural beauty. Pauline Johnson is sometimes considered to be part of this group of poets. See extra helpings if you wish to explore more about them and their poetry.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: William Willfred Campbell bio

∞ Article Link: William Douw Lighthall bio

∞ Article Link: Duncan Campbell Scott bio

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 57

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Carolyn Wells was an American writer who got her start working as a librarian before going on to write more than 170 books, including mystery novels, poetry, humor, and children's literature. She's best known for her long-running Fleming Stone detective series, which ran for 61 novels and helped pave the way for the Golden Age of mystery fiction. She was a passionate book collector who amassed an impressive collection of Walt Whitman works, which she donated to the Library of Congress when she passed away.

→ READ & DISCUSS

Limericks prove that poetry can be playful. Originating in the pubs of England (though named after the Irish city and county of Limerick), they also became popular in children's literature through the 1800s. They are composed of four or five lines with a bouncy AABBA rhyme pattern. Listen for the "bounce" as you read more limericks.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Carolyn Wells bio

★ TEACHER NOTE

St. Nicolas magazine was a popular children's magazine founded in 1873 and published until 1940, which contained stories, poems, and puzzles. Many famous writers were first published in its pages.

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p.208 " Limericks from St. Nicholas" on page 208 by Carolyn Wells

p.207-209 Read other limericks as time allows.

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 58

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.207-212 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

Chapter: Nonsense

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

- Try writing your own limerick. Most limericks start with "There once was" or "There was" and it's perfectly fine if they are a bit nonsensical!

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 59

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

The poem "The Song My Paddle Sings" used repetition and rhythm to mimic paddling. Today we'll read another of Johnson's poems about a dogsled. As you read the poem, look for repetition and listen to the rhythm. Can you hear the movement of the dogsled?

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.149 "The Train Dogs" by Pauline Johnson

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 60

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.8-9

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Link: Pauline Johnson Archives

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 61

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Henry David Thoreau was a poet, nature lover, and philosopher from Concord, Massachusetts. He spent his life finding beauty in the natural world and turning it into poetry and essays. Mentored by his friend and neighbor Ralph Waldo Emerson (who we read about in term one), he wrote over 20 volumes of poetry, journals, and essays. His poetry paints detailed, beautiful pictures of the woods, seasons, and wildlife he observed on his daily walks. His works have stayed popular for over 150 years.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.253-254 "Prayer" by Henry David Thoreau

- Note that "pelf" is an old word for money or wealth. It's usually used in a negative way. It shares its etymology with the word "pilfer".
- Thoreau is asking for help from God to meet his own high standards for himself. Why do you think he wants to "greatly disappoint my friends"?

• COMPOSITION

Henry David Thoreau is asking for help from God to meet his own high standards for himself in his poem "Prayer". Why do you think he wants to "greatly disappoint my friends"?

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WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 62

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Three poets we've discussed in previous weeks make an appearance again this week (Emerson, Longfellow, and Wilcox). What do you remember about Emerson?

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.253 "Forbearance" and "So Nigh Is Grandeur" by Ralph Waldo Emerson

- Use the author index in the back to find more poems by Ralph Waldo Emerson as time allows.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 63

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.149 Re-read "The Train Dogs" by Pauline Johnson

→ VIEW

∞ Link: Preserving Our Culture Dog sledding – A Métis Tradition

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 64

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.10-11

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Link: A Cry From An Indian Wife Poem

★ TEACHER NOTE

Content Consideration:

Illustrations of poems in the book show dead Indigenous warriors

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 65

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Walt Whitman grew up in Brooklyn, New York, left school at 11 to go to work, and went on to become one of the most important poets in American history. He self-published his famous poetry collection Leaves of Grass in 1855, which broke all the rules with its bold, free-flowing style, and he kept revising it for his whole life. During the Civil War, he volunteered as a nurse caring for wounded soldiers, and the experience inspired some of his most powerful poems. His influence has never faded, and his idea that poetry should sound like real people talking about real life continues to shape American writing to this day.

→ READ & DISCUSS

Notice the free verse structure Whitman is known for. There is no strict meter or rhyme scheme. Whitman mimics natural, spoken American speech, using repetition and long lists to build cadence.
p.258 "The commonplace"

→ VIEW

∞ Article Link: View 19th Century Commonplace Books of Poetry

→ READ & DISCUSS (OPTIONAL)

p.58 "Give Me The Splendid Sun" by Walt Whitman. If time allows, revisit this Walt Whitman poem from earlier in the year.

★ TEACHER NOTE

"The Commonplace" highlights Whitman's philosophy that ordinary life holds the highest value.

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WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 66

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

This poem was written "For Irish Children in Exile". Between 1845 and 1855, over 1.5 million adults and children immigrated from Ireland to America due to famine. The poem was a way to help them learn about (or remember) their homeland. It can be fun to read while trying to find some of the many places named on a map, if time allows.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.268 "The Geography of Ireland" by M.A., Sisters of Mercy

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Map Link: Map of Ireland

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 67

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Read the poem out loud and listen for the repetition and rhythm.

p.63 "Lady Icicle" by Pauline Johnson

- This poem uses personification. How does Johnson describe Little Lady Icicle?

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 68

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.12-14

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: This poem was based on the Battle of Cut Knife Hill (battle reenactment)

★ TEACHER NOTE

Content Consideration:

Illustrations of poems show dead Indigenous warriors

• COMPOSITION

The poem is written entirely from the wife's perspective. Now imagine the husband's point of view as he leaves. What might he be thinking and feeling? Write a poem or journal entry in his voice.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 69

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

You might not know her name, but you definitely know her work. Sarah Josepha Hale wrote "Mary Had a Little Lamb" and is also the woman most responsible for making Thanksgiving a national holiday! Born in New Hampshire in 1788, she turned to writing after her husband died young, leaving her with five children to support. She went on to publish poetry, novels, and essays throughout her life. She became the first female editor of an American magazine, using her platform to champion women's education and employment at a time when very few women had access to either. She spent 17 years writing letters to five different presidents lobbying for a national Thanksgiving holiday, and finally succeeded in 1863 when President Lincoln made it official!

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.280 "Birds" by Sarah Josepha Hale

p.281 "My Country" by Sarah Josepha Hale

- In Sarah Josepha Hale's poem "My Country" on page 281, each stanza

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ends in variations of the refrain "Where man is free" or "And all are free". This repetition emphasizes the foundational pride she felt in America. Perhaps this is not surprising since we know how hard she fought to make Thanksgiving a national holiday!

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 70

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.277-281 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.
Chapter: Slavery and Freedom
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 71

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.63 Re-read "Lady Icicle" by Pauline Johnson

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Musical Performance of "Lady Icicle"

- How does Johnson describe winter here? Does that differ from how we usually describe winter?
- Illustrate the poem with a picture of winter and/or Little Lady Icicle as Johnson describes them. (Optional)

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 72

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.15-16

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

In an acrostic poem, the first letter of each line forms a word. In this poem, they spell the name "CANADA" in this poem by Pauline Johnson.
∞ Link: "Canada"

- If time allows, write your own acrostic poem using the letters in your first name.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 73

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Christina Moody was a young African American poet who did something truly remarkable; she published her own book of poetry called A Tiny Spark when she was just sixteen years old! Her poems were bold and brave for their time, tackling big questions like what it really means to be Black in America and the complicated feelings of pledging allegiance to a country that didn't treat all of its people equally. The book is incredibly rare today, with only a handful of copies known to exist in the entire world. Not much is known about Christina's life beyond this one extraordinary book, but she was a courageous and talented young woman who deserves to be remembered.

→ READ & DISCUSS

Moody was between 13 and 16 years of age when she wrote these poems!

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Christina Moody bio

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p.294 "A Tale Told By Grandma" by Christina Moody
p.296 "The Depth From Whence We Came" by Christina Moody
p.298 "The Negro's Flag and Country" by Christina Moody

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 74

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.284 "The Tree of Slavery" Author Unknown
• A poem that takes a shape like this one is called a calligram.

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Article Link: How to Create a Calligram

• EXTRA HELPING

Create your own calligram poem.

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 75

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.530 Read "The Birds' Lullaby" by Pauline Johnson

• What lines are repeated in this poem? What rhythm or motion do those words give the poem?

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 76

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ INTRO

Pauline Johnson's home on the Six Nations Reserve was close to the Anglican mission where her father, George H.M. Johnson, worked. He was an interpreter and cultural negotiator between the Mohawk, the British, and the Government of Canada. Her family's Christian faith heavily influenced her poetry.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.17-18

→ READ (OPTIONAL)

∞ Article Link: Christmastide Poem

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 77

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Fenton Johnson was born in 1888 into one of Chicago's wealthiest African American families and attended top universities like the University of Chicago and Columbia. He wrote bold, free-verse poems about what life was really like for African Americans in the city, which was groundbreaking for his time. He even started his own literary magazines to help get new voices heard. He's considered one of the key figures who helped set the stage for the Harlem Renaissance, the incredible explosion of African American art, music, and literature that took off in the 1920s. He also wrote short stories, essays, and plays.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.306 "The Complaint of the Factory Child" by Fenton Johnson
• "The Complaint of the Factory Child" criticizes the exploitation of child labor during the Industrial Era. Read the poem again aloud and see if you can hear how the steady rhythm and repetition of the poem mimics the relentless machinery of the factories.

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WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 78

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.301-306 Pick and choose poems from these pages over the week.

Chapter: Politics and Social Reform

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 79

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.530 Read "The Birds' Lullaby" by Pauline Johnson.

- In a previous lesson, we discussed the repetition and rhythm of this poem. This time, as you read, move side to side slowly in rhythm with the poem.

- (Optional) Have one student (or group of students or teacher) read the end word of a line and another student (or group of students) read the end word of the next line that rhymes (creeping/sleeping, through/you, sighing/lying, reply/lullaby, lowly/slowly, strong/song).

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 80

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.19-20

→ VIEW

The birthplace of Pauline Johnson is now a National Historic Site in Canada.

∞ Link: Birthplace of Pauline Johnson

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 81

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Robert Frost is one of the most famous poets in American history, but his road to success was anything but smooth. He dropped out of college twice, worked as a chicken farmer, and had barely been published until he was almost 40! Desperate for a fresh start, he packed up his whole family and sailed to England in 1912. British publishers loved his writing, and he came back to America a celebrity. He went on to win four Pulitzer Prizes and wrote some of the most quoted lines in the English language.

→ READ & DISCUSS

Read Robert Frost's poem about Tenochtitlan, titled "La Noche Triste" on page 321. Written when he was just sixteen years old, it is the very first poem he ever composed and shows his early interest in history and human conflict.

p.321 "La Noche Triste"

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Robert Frost bio

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 82

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.321 "The Sachem Of The Clouds" by Robert Frost

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- This poem is written in a quatrain (4 lines per stanza) with an AABB rhyme scheme.

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 83

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.530-531 "Lullaby of the Iroquois" by Pauline Johnson

- Lullabies are usually sung, not read. Read a few lines of this poem aloud and pay attention to how it feels. Does hearing it change how you understand it compared to reading it silently?

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 84

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.21-23

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

West Wind Blow From Your Prairie Nest is an album dedicated to the indigenous culture of North America. Created at the Institute of American Indian Arts (IAIA), with the support of the CEC ArtsLink Fellowship, the album sets to music original poems written by renowned Native poets.
∞ Video Link: Musical Performance of "The Song My Paddle Sings" (Listen to all or part)

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 85

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

You might not know Anna Bartlett Warner's name, but there's a good chance you know her most famous words. She wrote the hymn "Jesus Loves Me," one of the most recognized songs in the world. Born in New York in 1827, she was a prolific writer who published 31 novels on her own and several more with her sister Susan, often writing under the pen name Amy Lothrop. She lived most of her life on Constitution Island, right across from the West Point Military Academy, and her family's home is now a museum that has been restored to look just as it did in her lifetime.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.330 "Jesus Loves Me" by Anna Bartlett Warner

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: Hymn Stories: Jesus Loves Me

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Anna Bartlett Warner bio

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 86

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.329 "Nearer Home" This poem is also a hymn that uses the first line as the title.

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

∞ Video Link: One Sweetly Solemn Thought

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WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 87

Materials: link

→ READ & DISCUSS

∞ Article Link: "The Homing Bee" by Pauline Johnson

- How many times does Johnson use the phrase "little brother"? At what point did you guess who the little brother was?
- (Optional) Based on the poems you've read so far by Pauline Johnson, what do you think she believed about the relationship between humans and nature?

• COMPOSITION

Based on the poems you've read so far by Pauline Johnson, what do you think she believed about the relationship between humans and nature?

WEEK 10 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 88

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.24-27

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

This brief news story is about a play that reenacts what Pauline's performances might have looked like.

∞ Video Link: Paddle Song One Woman Play

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 89

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Harriet McEwen Kimball was a poet and hymn writer from Portsmouth, New Hampshire. She was known in her day as "The Poetess of the Church." She was home educated by her mother, who was described as cultured and accomplished. She started writing poetry at a young age with her parents' encouragement and went on to publish several collections of deeply religious poetry and hymns that ended up in church songbooks all across the country. She was part of the same circle of poets as Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, was a personal friend with John Greenleaf Whittier, and was also a generous philanthropist.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.357 "The Fairy Taper" by Harriet McEwen Kimball

→ VIEW (OPTIONAL)

Ironically, while Harriet McEwen Kimball was best known for her hymns and religious poems, the only poem featured in our book is her poem about fairies! You can read some of her hymns at the link below.

∞ Website Link: Harriet McEwen Kimball Hymns

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Harriet McEwen Kimball bio

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 90

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Emily Dickinson appears in this chapter again with the poem "The Sea of Sunset". While the version in our book omits Dickinson's trademark em dashes, you can see how they were originally included in the link below. Try reading both versions out loud to see if the dashes make a difference in how the poem sounds.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.362 "The Sea of Sunset" by Emily Dickinson

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 2

→ VIEW

∞ Website Link: "The Sea of Sunset"

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 91

Materials: The Poet: Pauline Johnson

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.28-30

→ WRITE (OPTIONAL)

- Write and perform your own poem inspired by Pauline Johnson, just as Kathy did in the book. You can also work on this in the next lesson if you don't finish.

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 92

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

- Use the author index in the back of the book to revisit your favorite poems by Pauline Johnson.

OR

- Continue to work on your poem inspired by Pauline Johnson and perform it for someone.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 93

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 94

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 95

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 96

Exams

→ EXAM WEEK

There are no exams for this course.

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 97

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

John Greenleaf Whittier grew up on a farm in Massachusetts in the early 1800s, where his love of reading sparked a passion for writing poetry. His sister secretly sent one of his poems to a newspaper, which kicked off his whole career. Whittier became one of the loudest voices against slavery in America, even when it was dangerous to do so. He helped found the American Anti-Slavery Society and signed the Anti-Slavery Declaration of 1833. After slavery was abolished, he wrote cozy, heartfelt poems about New England life and became one of the most beloved poets in the country.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.371-372 "Red Riding-Hood" by John Greenleaf Whittier

- How does this poem about Red-Riding Hood differ from the traditional fairy tale?

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: John Greenleaf Whittier bio

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 98

□ Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Read the three poems about Mermaids on these pages. How are they similar or different?

p.368-369

- (Optional) Films like "The Little Mermaid" may make us think of mermaids as beautiful and harmless. However, Mermaids have been depicted in many ways throughout history, and are commonly seen as a sign of danger (such as an impending shipwreck). How are these mermaids depicted?

WEEK 1 □ 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 99

□ Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ INTRO

Paul Lawrence Dunbar was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other literary giants who would come after him. In fact, "I know why the caged bird sings" (one of the most iconic lines in African American literature and the title of Maya Angelou's autobiography) comes from one of Dunbar's poems. He was the only Black student in his high school, and became friends with Orville Wright and his brother Wilbur (who you may remember as the inventors of the airplane). The Wright brothers owned a printing press and published Dunbar's first writings. While Dunbar only lived to age 33, he has been described as "your favorite poet's favorite poet" due to the impact his large body of work had on future writers. Older students may want to read more about Dunbar in extra helpings.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.1-4

- Why do you think the book says "it's almost like two different men wrote those two poems"? What are some of the differences?

★ TEACHER NOTE

Content Consideration: Some illustrations in the book should be previewed by the teacher.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Paul Laurence Dunbar bio

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

WEEK 1 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 100

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.5-10

→ **VIEW**
∞ Image & Article Link: Fifth Massachusetts Colored Cavalry

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 101

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **INTRO**

Clement Clarke Moore was born in 1779 in New York City and became a college professor of ancient languages. On Christmas Eve 1822, he reportedly wrote a fun poem just to entertain his kids. That poem, "Account Of A Visit From St. Nicholas," was the first to give Santa's reindeer their names and went on to become one of the most beloved Christmas poems ever. It was published anonymously in a New York newspaper in 1823, and Moore didn't claim authorship until 1844. However, the family of another writer, Henry Livingston Jr., argued that he was the real author! Computer analysis in the early 2000s even suggested the poem had more in common with Livingston's known writing style than Moore's. So, the mystery of who really wrote 'Twas the Night Before Christmas may never be fully solved!

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.383-384 "Account Of A Visit From St. Nicholas" by Clement Clarke Moore

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 102

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **INTRO**

We learned about Henry Wadsworth Longfellow earlier this year, and today we will read his poem "Christmas Bells". Longfellow wrote this poem in 1863 at one of the lowest points of his life. His wife had recently died in a tragic accident, and his son had just been wounded fighting in the Civil War. He wrote "Christmas Bells" while sitting by his son's bedside. When he heard church bells ringing on Christmas morning, he was struck by the contrast between their message of peace and the suffering around him. That tension became his poem "Christmas Bells." However, when the poem was set to music in 1872, the stanzas referencing the Civil War were removed, and the title changed to "I Heard The Bells On Christmas Day". Today, millions of people sing the carol every holiday season.

→ **READ & DISCUSS**
p.389 "Christmas Bells" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- This popular poem was set to music pretty early on and has been recorded many times over the years. Listen to the version below if time allows.
∞ Video Link: Christmas Bells

- Read more about the story behind this poem in the link below, as time allows.
∞ Website Link: The Story behind "Christmas Bells"

• **EXTRA HELPING**

∞ **Video Link:** Christmas Bells Movie

Poetry Reading: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 3

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 103

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.11-16

WEEK 2 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 104

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.17-21

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 105

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **INTRO**

James Russell Lowell was born in 1819 in Cambridge, Massachusetts. He graduated from Harvard but was banned from the graduation ceremonies for breaking the rules! During his suspension, he stayed with a reverend in Concord, where he met poets Ralph Waldo Emerson and Henry David Thoreau, though his relationship with Thoreau would later sour. He skipped a career in law to pursue writing instead. His wife, Maria, strongly opposed slavery and pushed him toward more active involvement in the abolitionist cause. The couple gave their own money to help people escaping enslavement, even when times were tough financially. In 1849, he contributed toward purchasing a slave's freedom, writing, "if my poems were more popular, my gifts should be larger." Lowell also joined the Boston Vigilance Committee, a group that provided shelter, clothing, money, and safe passage to slaves seeking freedom on the Underground Railroad. Lowell became the first editor of the Atlantic Monthly and even served as U.S. Ambassador to Spain and Great Britain.

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

Fatherland means the country, nation, or land you came from. For example, Irish immigrants to America in the 1800s would call Ireland their fatherland.
p.408 "The Fatherland" by James Russell Lowell

- Look for repetition at the end of the stanzas in "The Fatherland". What do you think Lowell was trying to emphasize through this repetition?

• **EXTRA HELPING**

∞ **Article Link:** James Russell Lowell bio

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 106

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **INTRO**

In the last lesson, we read about poet James Russell Lowell. Later in life, Lowell succeeded his friend and fellow poet Henry Wadsworth Longfellow as Professor of Modern Languages at Harvard University. Today, we'll read one of Longfellow's most famous poems, titled "Paul Revere's Ride," about this famous event during the American Revolutionary War. Though "Paul Revere's Ride" is on the surface about a Revolutionary War event, it was written on the cusp of the Civil War. The poem was meant as a call to arms, rousing Northerners to action as war loomed.

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.410-413 "Paul Revere's Ride" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

• **EXTRA HELPING**

∞ **Article Link:** "Paul Revere's Ride" Awakening Abolitionists

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 107

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.22-24

WEEK 3 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 108

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.26-28

- Why do you think Paul's education was so important to his mother, Matilda?

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 109

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Oliver Wendell Holmes was born in Cambridge, Massachusetts. He became a professor of anatomy at Harvard Medical School and was eventually made its dean, a position he held until 1882. He was also one of the "Fireside Poets," beloved for writing poetry that families could enjoy together. His most famous poem, "Old Ironsides," helped save the historic warship USS Constitution from being scrapped by the Navy. His son was Oliver Wendell Holmes Jr., who became an Associate Justice of the Supreme Court of the United States. Holmes Jr. graduated from Harvard in 1861, right as the Civil War was breaking out, and enlisted in the Union Army. He was wounded three times, and his father wrote a famous essay about frantically searching for his son after the Battle of Antietam.

→ READ & DISCUSS

This poem was written for the centennial (100th) anniversary of this Revolutionary War battle. Watch for an interesting twist at the end of the poem regarding the legacy of an injured soldier.
p.413-417 "Grandmother's Story of Bunker-Hill Battle: As She Saw It From the Belfry" by Oliver Wendell Holmes

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ **Article Link:** Oliver Wendell Holmes bio

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 110

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

We learned about Walt Whitman earlier in the year, and today we'll read one of his most famous poems, titled "O Captain! My Captain!"

→ READ & DISCUSS

Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.
p.413-417 & 422-423 Chapter: Histories

- This poem is one of two memorial poems Whitman wrote about the assassination of President Abraham Lincoln. In the poem, Lincoln is the "captain," and the United States is the ship.

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 111

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.29-31

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: Black Soldiers in the Civil War

WEEK 4 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 112

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

We read "Little Orphant Annie" in a previous lesson, and will learn more about James Whitcomb Riley in an upcoming lesson!
p.32-36

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 113

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Charlotte Perkins Gilman was born in 1860 in Connecticut. She had a tough childhood and attended school sporadically at best. However, she loved reading in the library, and she especially loved "natural philosophy," which is what physics was called back then.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.437 "Little Cell" by Charlotte Perkins Gilman

→ WRITE (OPTIONAL)

- Charlotte Perkins Gilman's love of science may have influenced her to write "Little Cell." Try your hand today at writing a poem about a topic or object that isn't commonly featured in poetry.

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Charlotte Perkins Gilman bio

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 114

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.437-441 Chapter: Science and Technology
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

→ WRITE (OPTIONAL)

- Continue writing or revising your poem today if needed.

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 115

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.37-40

WEEK 5 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 116

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.41-44

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 117

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Lucy Larcom was born in 1824 in Beverly, Massachusetts, the ninth of ten children. She loved books from a very early age and read everything she

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Lucy Larcom bio

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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could find. According to her autobiography, she wrote and self-published her own poetry collections at just seven years old! When her father died, and her family needed money, she went to work in a cotton mill at age eleven, but she never stopped writing. She grew up to become a well-known poet, teacher, and author whose words are still remembered today.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.454 "What the Train Ran Over" by Lucy Larcom

- "What the Train Ran Over" by Lucy Larcom is considered a ballad. A ballad is a poem that tells a story and sometimes is set to music. Ballads are usually organized in quatrains of four lines with a catchy rhythm and lots of repetition.
- What other ballads have you read this year that told a story?

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 118

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Before reading the poem, read the description of samplers on page 470.
p.470 "Sarah Orne's Sampler" by Sarah Loring Bailey

- Explore these photos of samplers. Girls usually completed sewing their first sampler around age 8 or 9. (optional)
- ∞ Image Link: Photos of Samplers

→ WRITE (OPTIONAL)

- What would you embroider on a sampler? Choose a Bible verse or short poem, or write an original verse.

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 119

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.45-47 (stop after poem)

→ READ (OPTIONAL)

∞ Article Link: Frederick Douglass bio

WEEK 6 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 120

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.47-48 (start at "How do you suppose")

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 121

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.461-470 Chapter: Homework and Handwork
(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 122

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

William Oland Bourne was a writer, minister, and helper of others who

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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lived during the time of the Civil War. When soldiers were wounded in battle and lost their arms, he created a special newsletter called The Soldier's Friend to support them. Bourne even organized left-handed handwriting contests for veterans who had lost their right arms. Because of his work standing up for people with disabilities, he is considered a pioneer in disability rights. He also wrote poetry, books of fables, and stories for children.

→ READ & DISCUSS

"The Busy Knitter" uses repetition at the end of each stanza. As you read the poem out loud, listen for the recurring refrain "She was sitting, knitting, knitting", which mimics the rhythmic click-clack of knitting needles.

p.475 "The Busy Knitter" by William Oland Bourne

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 123

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.50-53

- Why do you think this poem is called a sermon? What is the message of the sermon?

WEEK 7 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 124

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.54-56

- What does the author mean when she says, "Studying a poem isn't like solving a problem in math"?

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 125

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p. 477 "A Song From the Suds" by Louisa May Alcott

- Why do you think Alcott chose to call this a "song"?
- Alcott wrote this poem during a time when most women, especially working-class women, had very few choices about how they spent their lives. Can a person find real joy in work they did not necessarily choose?
- (Optional) If time allows, use the author index in the back of the book to explore other poems by Louisa May Alcott.

• COMPOSITION

Louisa May Alcott wrote "A Song From the Suds" during a time when most women, especially working-class women, had very few choices about how they spent their lives. Can a person find real joy in work they did not necessarily choose? How?

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 126

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Paul Laurence Dunbar was the first poet we read about this year! You may remember that he was one of the first Black Americans to earn a living as a writer, and he inspired many other writers after him.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.486 "Little Brown Baby" by Paul Laurence Dunbar

→ VIEW

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∞ Video Link: Reading of "Little Brown Baby"

- Use any extra time to explore the author index on page 559 and revisit some of Dunbar's poems!

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 127

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.57-60 (stop after poem)

WEEK 8 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 128

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.60-66 (Start at "It was time")

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 129

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.485-487 Chapter: Family Ties

(Read one time, discuss, and then reread the poems.)

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 130

Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ **INTRO**

James Whitcomb Riley was a poet from Greenfield, Indiana, who loved making up rhymes even as a little kid. His very first poems were valentines he made for his friends! He skipped out on school as much as he could, preferring to wander outside and read on his own. He worked all kinds of odd jobs before becoming famous as a writer. He wrote about everyday people and the Indiana countryside in the way people actually talked, earning the nicknames "Hoosier Poet" and "Children's Poet." His best-known poems include "Little Orphant Annie" (which we read earlier) and "The Raggedy Man."

→ **READ & DISCUSS**

p.497 "The Raggedy Man" by James Whitcomb Riley

- Who is the Raggedy Man? What do we learn about him, and what does the poet leave unsaid?
- (Optional) Read a stanza slowly and then read it again faster. Which seems like a better fit?

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 131

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.67-71

• **COMPOSITION**

How did the hardships of Dunbar's childhood shape him as a writer and a person? Why do you think those same difficulties became a source of strength rather than holding him back?

WEEK 9 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 132

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.73-78

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WEEK 10 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 133

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.493 "The Children's Hour" by Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

- What is the rhyme structure of this poem? Which lines rhyme and which do not?
- This poem uses metaphor (a comparison of two things that are generally unlike) to compare the daughters' invasion of his study to a military siege. What words does Longfellow use that sound like a siege?

★ TEACHER NOTE

The rhyme structure is ABCB. This is a common ballad form, and it gives the poem a song-like, storytelling quality.

WEEK 10 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 134

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ INTRO

Mary Mapes Dodge was an influential 19th-century American author and editor, best remembered for her novel "Hans Brinker, or The Silver Skates." As the foundational editor of St. Nicholas Magazine, she played a massive role in shaping American children's literature, writing with a deep understanding of childhood imagination and innocence.

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.525 "The Sand Man" by Mary Mapes Dodge

• EXTRA HELPING

∞ Article Link: Mary Mapes Dodge bio

WEEK 10 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 135

📖 Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.79-84

WEEK 10 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 136

📖 Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.85-90

WEEK 11 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 137

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

p.525 "The Sand-Man" Paul Laurence Dunbar

- How is this poem about the sandman similar or different to the one we read yesterday (featured just below it on the page)?

WEEK 11 📅 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 138

📖 Materials: Over the River and Through the Woods

→ READ & DISCUSS

Lullabies are one of the oldest forms of poetry (usually sung) and are found in every culture.

p.526 "Lullaby" by Louisa May Alcott

- What qualities do you think make a good lullaby?
- As time allows, revisit some of Alcott's other poems by checking the author index on page 559.

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



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WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 139

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.91-93

• COMPOSITION

Was there a moment in Dunbar's life that surprised you, or a poem you particularly enjoyed? What does his story make you think about: being creative, being different, or being told you can't do something?

WEEK 11 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 140

Materials: Jump Back Paul

→ **RECAP, READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.95-100

→ **VIEW (OPTIONAL)**
∞ Video Link: Paul Laurence Dunbar Home

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 141

Exams

→ **EXAM WEEK**
There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 142

Exams

→ **EXAM WEEK**
There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 143

Exams

→ **EXAM WEEK**
There are no exams for this course.

WEEK 12 5m Poetry Reading: Grade 8 - Lesson 144

Exams

→ **EXAM WEEK**
There are no exams for this course.